

KEY DEVELOPMENT

THE ROMAN WAR MACHINE

Until the collapse of the western Roman empire in the 5th century CE, the Roman legions formed the most formidable army of the Ancient World. Primarily an infantry force, it underwent a number of changes during its time of dominance.

The early Roman army was a citizen militia, drawn mainly from the wealthier classes. It owed its early successes to Rome's ability to conscript large numbers of recruits in times of war, and to its formidable tactical organization and training, which were far superior to those of its Italian enemies. The early legions had three categories of heavy infantry – the *hastati*, who were the least experienced, the *principes*, the best-quality troops, and the *triarii*, the veterans. The *hastati* and *principes* were armed with heavy javelins (*pila*), whereas the *triarii* had thrusting spears (*hastae*). The legionaries were protected by bronze helmets and semi-cylindrical body shields and, from the mid-3rd century BCE, they were armed with a short sword – the *gladius hispaniensis* – that became known as their signature weapon.

Drawn up in these three lines – each divided into 10 maniples (units) of around 150 men – the legion fought in much the same way as many ancient armies. Supporting cavalry (*equites*) and light infantry (*velites*) would attempt to turn the enemy flank, while the heavy infantry tried to breach their opponents' line. Few armies could match the Romans in number or skill, but the legion suffered major setbacks when faced with the tactical genius of the Carthaginian general Hannibal, during the Second Punic War.

THE MARIAN REFORMS

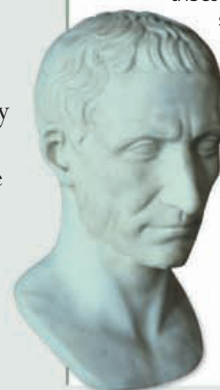
Although the Roman army ultimately won the Second Punic War, its performance during the 2nd century BCE was lacklustre and it struggled in

KEY FIGURE

JULIUS CAESAR

100–44 BCE

Roman general Julius Caesar secured his reputation in a series of campaigns in Gaul, from 58 to 50 BCE, securing large new provinces for Rome. Dogged and tactically adept, Caesar ruthlessly suppressed tribes who opposed him, such as the Belgae and Nervii, and was made dictator for life. Soon after, however, he was assassinated.



◀ At the time of his assassination, Julius Caesar was planning further military conquests, of the Dacians and the Parthians.

▼ THE BATTLE OF THE TREBIA

In 218 BCE, Hannibal turned the Roman flanks by defeating their cavalry, then attacking from the rear.

